

Student Ransomware Playbook

A plain-language guide for college and university students. How to spot phishing, protect your accounts and coursework, and know what to do if something goes wrong.

Created by Joshua Gerstenfeld and Scott Jacques with support from CrimConsortium (<https://crimconsortium.com>). Open access. Code MIT-licensed; content CC BY 4.0. Live site: <https://crimconsortium.github.io/student-ransomware-playbook/>

Protect yourself (before anything goes wrong)

- Turn on multi-factor authentication (MFA) for your campus account, email, and any system holding your records.
- Use a password manager and a unique password for your campus identity. Don't reuse it on other sites.
- Keep your laptop, phone, and browser updated. Install updates within 7 days of release.
- Back up your coursework to campus cloud storage (and a second copy where allowed). Don't rely on a single drive.
- Save the IT help desk and security team contact info in your phone before you need it.
- Complete any phishing or security training the campus offers. Even short modules build real skill.
- Review your account recovery options (backup email, phone) so an attacker can't reset your password.

Phishing red flags

- Urgency: "Your account will be locked in 24 hours."
- A login link in the message — type your campus URL into the browser yourself.
- Sender domain close but not exact (e.g., support@my-college.edu.help).
- Unexpected attachments — zip files, OneNote files, HTML "invoices."
- Offers too good to be true: surprise scholarships, refunds, high-paying student jobs.
- MFA prompts you didn't trigger. Never approve a prompt you didn't start.

And sometimes there are no red flags. A real account from someone you actually know — a friend, a professor, your RA, the campus help desk — can be compromised and used to send phishing. Same name, same email address, normal-looking signature. If a message asks you to click a link, log in somewhere, pay something, share an MFA code, or move money, treat the request with suspicion — not just the sender. Verify out-of-band: text or call the person on a number you already had, or walk over.

If something goes wrong

In the moment

- If a message, login page, or pop-up looks suspicious, stop. Don't click, don't enter credentials.
- If you already clicked or entered a password, change that password from a different device and report it now.
- If your device is acting strange (files renamed, ransom note, unexpected encryption), disconnect it from Wi-Fi and any cables, leave it powered on, and contact IT.
- Forward suspicious emails using the campus 'Report Phishing' button or as an attachment to the security team.
- Don't try to 'fix' a suspected infection yourself. Don't pay a ransom on a personal device. Call IT.
- Follow official guidance from the campus emergency channel. Ignore unverified rumors on social media.

After the dust settles

- Change passwords for any account that may have been exposed and review login history.
- Re-enable backups and confirm your important files are still recoverable.
- Tell classmates and roommates what you saw. Phishing campaigns usually target many students at once.
- Attend any post-incident briefings. They teach you the exact lure that worked so you can spot the next one.

Quick checklist

- MFA is on for my campus email and student portal.
- I use a password manager (or at least a unique password for school accounts).
- My laptop and phone install updates automatically.
- I have at least one backup of my coursework outside the device I use daily.
- I know how to report a phishing email on my campus.
- The IT help desk number is saved in my phone.
- I've reviewed my account recovery email and phone in the last 6 months.

FAQ

What even is ransomware, in plain terms?

Software that locks up your files (and usually steals copies first) so someone can charge you to unlock them, or to not leak them. As a student you mostly see the way in: phishing emails, fake login pages, and account takeovers.

Why should I care? Isn't this an IT problem?

Your account is the easiest way in. Universities have documented student accounts being taken over by phishing, then used to send more phishing to classmates from a trusted address, and to reset passwords or change account-recovery settings so attackers keep access even after the original password is changed. A single careless click can affect your grades, financial aid, and the people around you.

I think I clicked a phishing link. What now?

Stop using the device. From a different device (your phone is fine), change the password for the affected account, then call the campus IT help desk. Keep the original message. IT may need it. Speed matters more than embarrassment.

My laptop is showing a ransom note. What should I do?

Don't pay anything. Disconnect from Wi-Fi and unplug any cables, but leave the device powered on (forensics may need volatile memory). Call campus IT right now. Don't try to 'fix' it yourself.

Is the campus going to discipline me if I report a mistake?

Many campuses encourage honest reporting and treat accidental clicks differently from intentional misconduct. They need the data to defend everyone. Check your campus policy, but in general the cost of not reporting is worse than the cost of reporting.

Should I use a personal device for schoolwork?

Generally fine if it's up to date, has MFA on your campus account, and you don't pirate software on it. Some courses or programs (e.g., clinical, legal, research with sensitive data) require institution-managed devices. Check your syllabus.

Is MFA actually worth the hassle?

Yes. Multi-factor authentication is one of the most important things you can do to protect an account, and CISA recommends it for everyone. Phishing-resistant MFA (FIDO2 / passkeys / hardware keys like YubiKey) is the strongest form because the credential is bound to the legitimate site. Enable it wherever your campus offers it.

Is public Wi-Fi at the coffee shop dangerous?

Less than it used to be. Most sites and apps use HTTPS by default. Still a good idea to avoid logging into your campus account from networks you don't trust, and to use your campus VPN if your school provides one.

Can this site substitute for legal advice?

No. This is a plain-language educational summary. Specific obligations under FERPA, state breach laws, or your campus policies depend on your situation. Talk to your IT help desk, dean of students, or campus counsel.

Glossary

After-action review (AAR) — A structured, blameless review held after an incident to capture what happened, what worked, what didn't, and what to change. Produces a written report with tracked actions.

Backups (immutable / offline) — Copies of data that can't be altered or deleted by a normal admin (immutable) or are physically disconnected (offline). Critical for ransomware recovery.

CISA — U.S. Cybersecurity and Infrastructure Security Agency. Publishes the #StopRansomware guide and maintains free resources for higher education.

Command and control (C2) — Infrastructure attackers use to communicate with malware on compromised systems. Blocking C2 helps stop ongoing attacks.

Containment — Steps that stop an attack from spreading further: isolating hosts, disabling accounts, revoking sessions, blocking outbound traffic.

Decryption key — The key needed to reverse ransomware encryption. May or may not be supplied by attackers after payment; sometimes published by law enforcement.

Detection — Identifying that an intrusion or attack is occurring or has occurred, ideally before damage is done.

Endpoint Detection and Response (EDR) — Software that monitors laptops, desktops, and servers for malicious behavior and supports investigation and response.

FERPA — Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act (U.S.). Governs the privacy of student education records and shapes notification obligations.

FIDO2 / WebAuthn — Phishing-resistant authentication standards. Hardware keys and platform authenticators (Touch ID, Face ID, Windows Hello) implement them.

Incident Commander — The single person responsible for directing the response during an incident, regardless of normal seniority.

Indicator of Compromise (IOC) — An observable artifact (file hash, IP, domain, behavior) that suggests a system has been attacked.

MFA / Multi-factor authentication — Requiring more than a password to sign in, typically a code or hardware key. Phishing-resistant MFA (FIDO2/WebAuthn) binds the credential to the real site, so it cannot be replayed on a fake login page.

MFA fatigue — Attack where an attacker repeatedly triggers MFA prompts hoping the user approves one out of frustration.

NIST — U.S. National Institute of Standards and Technology. Publishes the Cybersecurity Framework and SP 800-61 for incident response.

Phishing — Deceptive messages (email, SMS, voice, web) that trick users into entering credentials, running malware, or approving fraudulent transactions.

Ransomware — Malware that encrypts files and/or steals data, then demands payment to restore access or to prevent publication.

RDP — Remote Desktop Protocol. Frequently abused by attackers when exposed to the internet without strong controls.

Segmentation — Dividing a network into zones so a compromise in one area can't spread freely to others.

Tabletop exercise — A facilitated discussion-based drill where leaders walk through their response to a hypothetical incident.

Third-party risk — Risk introduced by vendors, SaaS providers, and contractors. Recent higher-ed ransomware impact has been driven heavily by exploited third-party software.

Sources

CISA Secure Our World — Plain-language consumer guidance from the U.S. Cybersecurity & Infrastructure Security Agency on MFA, phishing, passwords, and updates.

<https://www.cisa.gov/secureourworld>

CISA #StopRansomware — U.S. CISA hub of ransomware guidance, including how to report an incident.

<https://www.cisa.gov/stopransomware>

National Cybersecurity Alliance — StaySafeOnline — General-public cybersecurity basics, including phishing, passwords, and account safety.

<https://staysafeonline.org/online-safety-privacy-basics/>

EDUCAUSE: Cybersecurity Awareness for College Students — Higher-ed-focused student safety tips from Purdue/EDUCAUSE.

<https://library.educase.edu/resources/2020/9/cybersecurity-awareness-for-college-students-7-things-to-do-now>

Federal Trade Commission — Identity Theft and Online Security — U.S. FTC guidance for individuals on online privacy, scams, and recovering from identity theft.

<https://consumer.ftc.gov/identity-theft-and-online-security/online-privacy-and-security>

FBI Internet Crime Complaint Center (IC3) — Where U.S. individuals and institutions can report cyber incidents to the FBI.

<https://www.ic3.gov/>

Higher Ed Dive: Ransomware in Education, H1 2025 — Reporting on the scale and trends of ransomware affecting colleges and schools.

<https://www.highereddive.com/news/ransomware-attacks-education-jump-23-percent-h1-2025/754011/>

University of Utah ISO: Students Face Increasing Phishing and Other Cyberattacks (2021) — University of Utah Information Security Office advisory documenting compromised student accounts and attackers using socially-engineered information to reset passwords and maintain access.

<https://attheu.utah.edu/announcements/students-face-increasing-phishing-and-other-cyberattacks/>

The Maroon Tiger: Several Morehouse students fall victim to phishing emails (2025) — Student newspaper reporting, with Morehouse College ITS confirmation, of compromised student accounts being used to send phishing to other students (fake job, work-study, and direct-funding lures).

<https://maroontigermedia.com/2025/08/phishing-morehouse-emails-student-hacking/>

Tischer et al., 'Users Really Do Plug in USB Drives They Find' (IEEE Security & Privacy, 2016) — University of Illinois / Google research demonstrating that 45-98% of dropped USB drives were plugged in by finders, with first drives connected in under six minutes.

<https://research.google/pubs/users-really-do-plug-in-usb-drives-they-find/>

No More Ransom Project — Europol-backed clearinghouse of legitimate, free ransomware decryption tools. Use only at the direction of IT or law enforcement, never as a first response.

<https://www.nomoreransom.org/>